months, since Pallonji resigned from it in December 2004 and Cyrus was appointed to it only in August 2006.

Ratan avers that though his interactions with Mistry were largely limited to Tata Sons board meetings, he was impressed with him. When Ratan was able to observe him at close quarters while Mistry was the deputy chairman, he was reassured.

But by the end of the one year of parallel running, Ratan began to have second thoughts about Mistry's suitability as the chairman-designate. He recalls that some of the latter's 'sharp interventions' had surprised him. Deep down, he pondered if it would be prudent to appoint a man whose ethos could potentially conflict with that of the Tatas.

Mistry had a particular talent to identify potential pitfalls in strategies, Ratan adds. He was not sure if Mistry would use these qualities for the benefit of Tata Sons and whether he would always uphold the fundamental values of the group, he says. Nevertheless, he gave the incumbent chairman the benefit of the doubt.

While Ratan later lamented that he did not have the opportunity to fully assess the new chairman, many of his critics blame him for bringing the situation upon himself by choosing to stay away from the selection committee. They contend that he should have helped the committee with the wisdom and judgement he had gained after having spent half a century in the group and more than two decades at the apex. He could have assisted the committee in choosing the best candidate. He also owed it to the millions of Tata shareholders to be involved in the selection of the group chairman.